



Golden Age of Steamboats

The Golden Age of River Steamboats is roughly the period from 1850 – 1870. Specifically the ten years before the Civil War and the few years afterward were the best for packets on the Mississippi, Missouri, and Ohio Rivers and their tributaries. In those days cabin passage on a packet was luxurious. Cut glass chandeliers in the parlor, oil paintings in every stateroom, gilded mirrors and marble tables, thick carpets, and steaming foods piled high. Life on the rivers was at its best. Neither homes nor hotels of the 1850's could provide such comfort. Everyone whose life centered on the river was prosperous. Even the crew walked with a swagger jingling their plentiful silver.

The Civil War changed every aspect of the rivers. Boats that carried passengers in luxury were packed with troops and supplies. These civilian wooden hull warcraft had no protection other than a few iron plates shielding the pilot house. Often fired upon from the banks of the western rivers, many were captured, looted, and burned. More fortunate steamers were simply riddled with holes. Their work was dangerous while their pay, if any, was reduced to well below the commercial rates before the war. As civilians, they were not entitled to pensions, yet they were subject to the same harsh treatment as prisoners of war if captured. Many of the independent owner/operators never recovered from the financial hardships caused by the war. These hardy steamboat men took the hard knocks but without the glory.

The Civil War was the first of two disasters that brought an end to the steamboat days. The second came creeping from the east on steel rails after the war – the iron horse. From then on steamboats were practically useless. They had done their job of settling a continent, and had done it well with style. Few people had expected that railroads would make the proud packets a thing of the past. As railroad locomotives grew more powerful and numerous, steamboats became fewer and disheveled. First the pineapple tops of the lofty stacks disappeared followed by the stained glass windows and cut glass chandeliers. Gradually even fresh paint was seen less frequently.

And so the golden days of the packet were over, replaced by railroads on one hand and by the tug boat and barges on the other.

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